

Print Culture and the Modern World

Social Science — History • Chapter 5 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Imagine a world where every book is hand-copied — taking months. That was the world before printing. The spread of **print technology** from China through East Asia to Europe and then back to colonial Asia transformed not just how knowledge spread, but how people thought, debated, dreamed and rebelled. This chapter tells that long story — from Chinese woodblocks to Gutenberg's press, the Reformation, the Enlightenment, the French Revolution, and India's nationalist and reform movements.

The first printed books — China, Japan, Korea

China had print technology earliest:

- **Woodblock printing** from AD 594 onwards — pages rubbed against inked wooden blocks; Buddhist and civil-service exam books printed in huge numbers by the imperial state.
- **Diamond Sutra** (AD 868) — oldest known printed book.
- Korea developed **movable metal type** by 13th century. Japanese Buddhist missionaries brought woodblock printing to Japan in the 8th century.
- China's print culture remained tied to bureaucracy until 17th century — then merchants, urban culture, fiction (women writers, romances, plays) flourished.

Print arrives in Europe — Gutenberg's revolution

Marco Polo brought woodblock printing to Italy in 1295. As demand for books grew, hand-copying could not keep up. **Johann Gutenberg** of Strasbourg developed the first printing press around 1448 using **movable metal type** — adapting wine and olive presses. His **Gutenberg Bible** (1454-55) was the first printed book in Europe. By 1500, ~20 million printed books were circulating in Europe; by 1600, 200 million.

The print revolution and its impact

- **New reading public** — books became cheaper, more accessible to common people. Earlier 'hearing public' became 'reading public'. Visual material (illustrations, woodcuts) helped less-literate readers.
- **Religious debates** — **Martin Luther's 95 theses (1517)** against the Roman Catholic Church spread rapidly via print, igniting the **Protestant Reformation**. Luther himself called print 'the ultimate gift of God'.
- **Reading mania** in 17th-18th century Europe — almanacs, ritual calendars, ballads, folktales. Newspapers and journals.
- **Print and dissent** — Roman Catholic Church set up the **Index of Prohibited Books** (1558) to censor heretical material. But ideas could no longer be controlled.
- **Print and the Enlightenment** — works of Voltaire, Rousseau, Diderot questioned authority, monarchy, religion. By 1780s, public discussion via books and pamphlets created a critical political culture — one cause of the **French Revolution (1789)**.

19th century — print for the masses

- Primary education spread; mass literacy across Europe.
- Children's books (Grimm Brothers' *fairy tales*, 1812).
- Women novelists: Jane Austen, Brontë sisters, George Eliot — created the modern individual.
- Cheap 'penny chapbooks' for working-class readers.
- **Lending libraries** from 17th century were tools of self-improvement.
- Power-driven cylindrical presses (mid-19th century) printed 8000 sheets/hour; offset press allowed colour printing.

India: Print, religion and reform

Print arrived in India with Portuguese missionaries in Goa in the mid-16th century (Tamil books in 1579). But it took off only with the Bengali press in late 18th century. James Augustus Hickey began the **first newspaper in**

India — 'Bengal Gazette' (1780).

- Vernacular newspapers and journals exploded in 19th century — religious reform, social issues, politics.
- **Raja Rammohan Roy** published *Sambad Kaumudi* (1821); debates on sati, widow remarriage, idolatry, education raged through print.
- Religious texts came within reach of common readers — *Tulsidas's Ramcharitmanas*, Persian texts, Quran in Urdu — strengthening communities, but also sharpening differences.
- **Women** like Rashsundari Devi (Bengali, ~1876, *Amar Jiban* — first full-length autobiography in Bengali by a woman) used print to express experience of seclusion. Tarabai Shinde and Pandita Ramabai wrote about plight of upper-caste women.
- Caste reformers — Jyotiba Phule's *Gulamgiri* (1871), Periyar — used print to attack caste oppression.

Print, censorship and the freedom struggle

British administrators wanted control. The **Vernacular Press Act (1878)** — modelled on Irish Press Laws — gave the government powers to censor and confiscate Indian-language papers. Despite this, nationalist papers like **Kesari** (Tilak), **Amrita Bazar Patrika**, **Bombay Samachar** turned print into a powerful weapon of mass mobilisation. By the 20th century, print was inseparable from the freedom movement.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Earliest print: China (woodblock, AD 594); Diamond Sutra (AD 868) – oldest printed book.
- Gutenberg invented printing press in Europe (~1448); Gutenberg Bible 1454-55.
- Martin Luther's 95 theses (1517) → Protestant Reformation, made possible by print.
- Index of Prohibited Books – Catholic Church censorship from 1558.
- First Indian newspaper: Bengal Gazette (Hickey, 1780).
- Raja Rammohan Roy's *Sambad Kaumudi* (1821); Rashsundari Devi's *Amar Jiban* (1876).
- Vernacular Press Act 1878 → censorship; *Kesari*, *Bombay Samachar* fought back.

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